A Few Notes on Vector Calculus

David Meyer

dmm@1-4-5.net

Last update: March 14, 2022

1 Introduction

TBD

2 Notation

Some of the notation we'll use is described in this section.

2.1 Vectors

Some authors use bold font to denote a vector. Adding a "hat" denotes a unit vector. That is, for a vector $\mathbf{u}$, $\hat{\mathbf{u}}$ is defined to be

$$\hat{\mathbf{u}} = \frac{\mathbf{u}}{\|\mathbf{u}\|}$$

In words: $\hat{\mathbf{u}}$ is a vector of unit length in the $\mathbf{u}$ direction.

$\hat{\mathbf{i}}$, $\hat{\mathbf{j}}$, and $\hat{\mathbf{i}}$ are the unit vectors in $\mathbb{R}^3$ in the x, y, and z directions respectively. Note that $\hat{\mathbf{i}}$, $\hat{\mathbf{j}}$, and $\hat{\mathbf{k}}$ are also basis vectors in $\mathbb{R}^3$ [2] and have column vector format

$$\hat{\mathbf{i}} = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \ \hat{\mathbf{j}} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \ \hat{\mathbf{k}} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Using these definitions we can define the parametric form of some curve C in $\mathbb{R}^3$, $\mathbf{r}(t)$, as follows:

$$\mathbf{r}(t) = g(t)\hat{\mathbf{i}} + h(t)\hat{\mathbf{j}} + k(t)\hat{\mathbf{k}}$$

where $t \in [a, b]$ and $g(t)$, $h(t)$, and $k(t)$ are scalar functions[1].

Another common notation for vectors is $\vec{r}(t)$, where $\vec{r}(t)$ might be defined as follows:

$$\vec{r}(t) = g(t)\hat{i} + h(t)\hat{j} + k(t)\hat{k}$$

In this document I'll use these notations interchangeably.

[1] A scalar function is a function f such that $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$.

3 Definitions and a Few Theorems

Definition 3.1. Dot Product: The dot product (aka scalar product or inner product) of two column vectors $\mathbf{a} = (a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_n)$ and $\mathbf{b} = (b_1, b_2, \ldots, b_n)$, where $\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, is defined to be the scalar value

$$\mathbf{a} \cdot \mathbf{b} = \langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b} \rangle = \sum_{j=1}^{n} a_j b_j = \mathbf{a}^\intercal \mathbf{b}$$

According to the Pythagorean theorem, the length of a vector $\mathbf{a} = (a_1, a_2, a_3) \in \mathbb{R}^3$, denoted $\|\mathbf{a}\|$, equals $\sqrt{a_1^2 + a_2^2 + a_3^2}$. The next definition is a generalization of the notion of length to vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Definition 3.2. Euclidean Norm: The Euclidean norm of a vector

$$\mathbf{a} = (a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_n) \in \mathbb{R}^n$$

is defined to be

$$\|\mathbf{a}\| = \sqrt{\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{a} \rangle} = \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_j^2} \tag{1}$$

Theorem 3.1. Cauchy–Schwarz Inequality:

$$\big|\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b} \rangle\big| \leq \|\mathbf{a}\| \|\mathbf{b}\|$$

Proof: The inequality is trivial if either $\mathbf{a}$ or $\mathbf{b}$ is zero, so assume that neither is. Now, let $\mathbf{x} = \frac{\mathbf{a}}{\|\mathbf{a}\|}$ and $\mathbf{y} = \frac{\mathbf{b}}{\|\mathbf{b}\|}$ and so $\|\mathbf{x}\| = \|\mathbf{y}\| = 1$ ($\mathbf{x} = \hat{\mathbf{a}}$ and $\mathbf{y} = \hat{\mathbf{b}}$).

Then one way to prove the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality is to use the reverse triangle inequality:

$$\big|\|\mathbf{x}\| - \|\mathbf{y}\|\big| \leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| \tag{2}$$

We can get the reverse triangle inequality from the triangle inequality [5, 8] by observing that

$$\begin{aligned}
\|\mathbf{x}\| &= \|\mathbf{x} + (-\mathbf{y} + \mathbf{y})\| && \text{\# add 0 to } \mathbf{x}\text{: } \mathbf{x} = \mathbf{x} + 0 = \mathbf{x} + (-\mathbf{y} + \mathbf{y}) \\
&= \|(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}) + \mathbf{y}\| && \text{\# addition is associative: } \mathbf{v}_1 + (\mathbf{v}_2 + \mathbf{v}_3) = (\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2) + \mathbf{v}_3 \\
&\leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| + \|\mathbf{y}\| && \text{\# by the triangle inequality: } \|\mathbf{v}_1 + \mathbf{v}_2\| \leq \|\mathbf{v}_1\| + \|\mathbf{v}_2\| \\
&\Rightarrow \|\mathbf{x}\| \leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| + \|\mathbf{y}\| && \text{\# combine expressions for } \|\mathbf{x}\| \\
&\Rightarrow \|\mathbf{x}\| - \|\mathbf{y}\| \leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| && \text{\# subtract } \|\mathbf{y}\| \text{ from both sides}
\end{aligned}$$

and

$$
\begin{aligned}
\|\mathbf{y}\| &= \|\mathbf{y} + (-\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{x})\| && \text{\# add 0 to } \mathbf{y}\text{: } \mathbf{y} = \mathbf{y} + 0 = \mathbf{y} + (-\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{x}) \\
&= \|(\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}) + \mathbf{x}\| && \text{\# addition is associative} \\
&\leq \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}\| + \|\mathbf{x}\| && \text{\# by the triangle inequality} \\
&\Rightarrow \|\mathbf{y}\| \leq \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}\| + \|\mathbf{x}\| && \text{\# combine expressions for } \|\mathbf{y}\| \\
&\Rightarrow \|\mathbf{y}\| - \|\mathbf{x}\| \leq \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}\| && \text{\# subtract } \|\mathbf{x}\| \text{ from both sides} \\
&\Rightarrow -\Big[\|\mathbf{y}\| - \|\mathbf{x}\|\Big] \geq -\|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}\| && \text{\# multiply both sides by -1: } -1 * (\mathbf{v}_1 \leq \mathbf{v}_2) \Rightarrow -\mathbf{v}_1 \geq -\mathbf{v}_2 \\
&\Rightarrow \|\mathbf{x}\| - \|\mathbf{y}\| \geq -\|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| && \text{\# } \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}\| = \|-(\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x})\| = \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| \text{ by Equation (1)} \\
&\Rightarrow -\|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| \leq \|\mathbf{x}\| - \|\mathbf{y}\| && \text{\# rearrange}
\end{aligned}
$$

Combining these two statements gives us the reverse triangle inequality (Equation (2)):

$$
-\|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| \leq \|\mathbf{x}\| - \|\mathbf{y}\| \leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| \Rightarrow \big|\|\mathbf{x}\| - \|\mathbf{y}\|\big| \leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\|
$$

Using the reverse triangle inequality we can see that

$$
\begin{aligned}
\big|\|\mathbf{x}\| - \|\mathbf{y}\|\big| &\leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| && \text{\# reverse triangle inequality (Equation (2))} \\
&\Rightarrow 0 \leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| && \text{\# } \|\mathbf{x}\| = \|\mathbf{y}\| = 1 \text{ by definition above, } 1 - 1 = 0,\ |0| = 0 \\
&\Rightarrow 0 \leq \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\|^2 && \text{\# } \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| \geq 0 \Rightarrow \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\|^2 \geq 0 \\
&\Rightarrow 0 \leq \sum_{j=1}^{n} (x_j - y_j)^2 && \text{\# } \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\|^2 = \sum_{j=1}^{n} (x_j - y_j)^2 \text{ by Equation (1)} \\
&\Rightarrow 0 \leq \sum_{j=1}^{n} \left(x_j^2 - 2x_j y_j + y_j^2\right) && \text{\# expand previous line} \\
&\Rightarrow 0 \leq \sum_{j=1}^{n} x_j^2 - 2\sum_{j=1}^{n} x_j y_j + \sum_{j=1}^{n} y_j^2 && \text{\# sum is a linear operator} \\
&\Rightarrow 0 \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|^2 - 2\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle + \|\mathbf{y}\|^2 && \text{\# } \|\mathbf{v}\|^2 = \sum_{j=1}^{n} v_j^2 \text{ and } \langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle = \sum_{j=1}^{n} x_j y_j \text{ by Equation (1)} \\
&\Rightarrow 0 \leq 1 - 2\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle + 1 && \text{\# } \|\mathbf{x}\| = \|\mathbf{y}\| = 1 \Rightarrow \|\mathbf{x}\|^2 = \|\mathbf{y}\|^2 = 1 \\
&\Rightarrow 0 \leq 2 - 2\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle && \text{\# } 1 + 1 = 2 \\
&\Rightarrow -2 \leq -2\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle && \text{\# subtract 2 from both sides} \\
&\Rightarrow 1 \geq \langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle && \text{\# divide by -2, reversing inequality} \\
&\Rightarrow \langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle \leq 1 && \text{\# rearrange} \\
&\Rightarrow \left\langle \frac{\mathbf{a}}{\|\mathbf{a}\|}, \frac{\mathbf{b}}{\|\mathbf{b}\|} \right\rangle \leq 1 && \text{\# } \mathbf{x} = \frac{\mathbf{a}}{\|\mathbf{a}\|},\ \mathbf{y} = \frac{\mathbf{b}}{\|\mathbf{b}\|} \text{ by definition above} \\
&\Rightarrow \frac{\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle}{\|\mathbf{a}\|\|\mathbf{b}\|} \leq 1 && \text{\# scalar multiplication rule: } \langle c_1\mathbf{v}_1, c_2\mathbf{v}_2\rangle = c_1 c_2 \langle \mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2\rangle \\
&\Rightarrow \langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle \leq \|\mathbf{a}\|\|\mathbf{b}\| && \text{\# multiply both sides by } \|\mathbf{a}\|\|\mathbf{b}\|
\end{aligned}
$$

If we replace $\mathbf{a}$ by $-\mathbf{a}$ we see by Equation (1) that $\|-\mathbf{a}\| = \|\mathbf{a}\|$. Further, by the scalar multiplication rule for dot products with $c_1 = -1$ and $c_2 = 1$ we have $\langle -\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle = -\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle$. Taken together these results imply that[2]

$$-\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle \leq \|\mathbf{a}\|\|\mathbf{b}\|$$

Next note that the absolute value of x, $|x|$, is defined to be

$$|x| = \begin{cases} x, & \text{if } x \geq 0 \\ -x, & \text{if } x < 0. \end{cases} \tag{3}$$

So one way to see the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality is by setting x equal to $\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle$ in Equation (3). Then when $\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle \geq 0$ we have $\left|\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle\right| = \langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle$ and we showed above that $\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle \leq \|\mathbf{a}\|\|\mathbf{b}\|$. Similarily, when $\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle < 0$ we have $\left|\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle\right| = -\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle$ and we showed that $-\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle \leq \|\mathbf{a}\|\|\mathbf{b}\|$. Together these give us $\left|\langle \mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}\rangle\right| \leq \|\mathbf{a}\|\|\mathbf{b}\|$, namely, the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality. □

3.1 Derivatives

We will also denote the derivative of a vector $\mathbf{r}$ with respect to t by $\dot{\mathbf{r}}$, $\dfrac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt}$ or $\mathbf{r}'(t)$. Note also that by definition

$$\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} = \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \frac{\mathbf{r}(t + \Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)}{\Delta t}$$

3.2 Vector Fields

In vector calculus and physics, a vector field is an assignment of a vector to each point in a subset of space [3]. For example, a vector field in the plane can be visualized as a collection of arrows with a given magnitude and direction, each attached to a point in the plane. Vector fields are often used to model the speed and direction of a moving fluid throughout space, or the strength and direction of some force, such as the magnetic or gravitational force, as it changes from one point to another point.

For example, the wind velocity vector field for the 2011 Joplin, MO tornado [6] is shown in Figure 1. Here the color represents the wind speed $\|\mathbf{v}\|$, where $\mathbf{v}$ is the wind velocity vector.

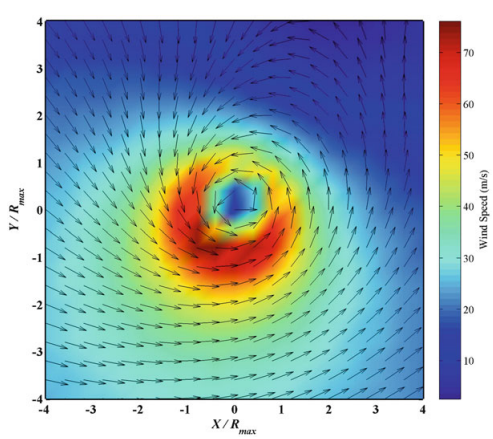

Figure 1: 2011 Joplin, MO Tornado Wind Velocity Vector Field

[2]There is nothing special about using $\mathbf{a}$ here. We could use $\mathbf{b}$ and get the same result.

The general form of a vector field (here in three dimensions) is

$$\vec{\mathbf{F}}(x, y, z) = P(x, y, z)\,\hat{\mathbf{i}} + Q(x, y, z)\,\hat{\mathbf{j}} + R(x, y, z)\,\hat{\mathbf{k}}$$

where P, Q, and R are scalar functions. That is, they are functions f such that $f : \mathbb{R}^3 \to \mathbb{R}$.

4 Arc Length

Consider a segment of a parametric curve $\mathbf{r}(t) = g(t)\,\hat{\mathbf{i}} + h(t)\,\hat{\mathbf{j}} + k(t)\,\hat{\mathbf{k}}$ between two points $P = \mathbf{r}(t)$ and $Q = \mathbf{r}(t + \Delta t)$, as shown in Figure 2.

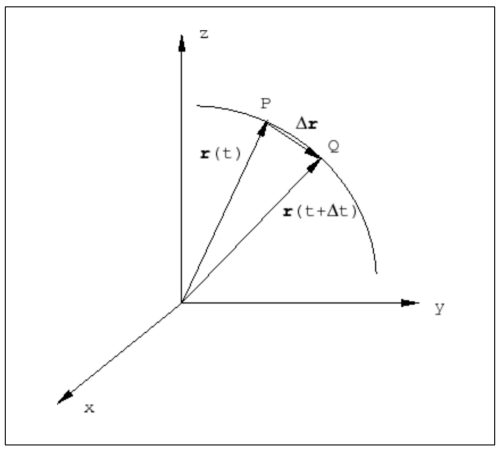

Figure 2: $\Delta\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{r}(t + \Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)$

What is the length of the segment of the curve between P and Q? This length is called the arc length and is denoted by Δs. Δs can be approximated by the chord length $\|\Delta\mathbf{r}\|$. Then we can compute the infinitesimal arc length ds as follows:

$$
\begin{aligned}
\Delta s &\approx \|\Delta \mathbf{r}\| && \text{\# approximate } \Delta s \text{ by } \|\Delta \mathbf{r}\| \\
&= \|\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)\| && \text{\# } \Delta \mathbf{r} = \mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t) \\
&= \|\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)\| \cdot \frac{\Delta t}{\Delta t} && \text{\# multiply by } 1 = \frac{\Delta t}{\Delta t} \\
&= \left\| \frac{\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)}{\Delta t} \right\| \cdot \Delta t && \text{\# assume } \Delta t > 0 \\
\Rightarrow\ & \Delta s = \left\| \frac{\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)}{\Delta t} \right\| \cdot \Delta t && \text{\# combine expressions for } \Delta s\ (\approx \to = \ ?) \\
\Rightarrow\ & \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \Delta s = \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \left[\left\| \frac{\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)}{\Delta t} \right\| \cdot \Delta t \right] && \text{\# take the limit of both sides} \\
\Rightarrow\ & ds = \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \left[\left\| \frac{\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)}{\Delta t} \right\| \cdot \Delta t \right] && \text{\# } \Delta t \to 0 \Rightarrow \Delta s \to 0 \Rightarrow \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \Delta s = ds \\
\Rightarrow\ & ds = \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \left\| \frac{\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)}{\Delta t} \right\| \cdot \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \Delta t && \text{\# product rule for limits [1]} \\
\Rightarrow\ & ds = \left\| \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \frac{\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)}{\Delta t} \right\| \cdot \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \Delta t && \text{\# for a normed vector space } X\ \lim \|x_n\| = \|\lim x_n\| \\
\Rightarrow\ & ds = \left\| \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} \right\| \cdot dt && \text{\# } \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \frac{\mathbf{r}(t+\Delta t) - \mathbf{r}(t)}{\Delta t} = \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt},\ \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \Delta t = dt
\end{aligned}
$$

Interestingly we can also see this using the Pythagorean theorem. Specifically, if we move an infinitesimal distance in the x and y directions we get a triangle in the x-y plane who's sides have length dx and dy and who's hypotenuse is ds. This scenario is shown for some curve $f(x)$ in Figure 3.

In the two dimensional case where the parameterization is $x = g(t)$ and $y = h(t)$ we have $\mathbf{r}(t) = g(t)\,\hat{\mathbf{i}} + h(t)\,\hat{\mathbf{j}}$. Further, since derivative is a linear operator [7] we know that

$$
\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} = \frac{dg}{dt}\,\hat{\mathbf{i}} + \frac{dh}{dt}\,\hat{\mathbf{j}} \tag{4}
$$

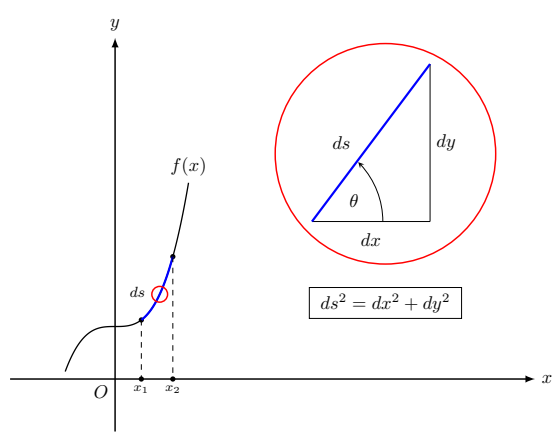

Figure 3: $f(x)$, ds and the Pythagorean Theorem

So in the source domain the Pythagorean theorem tells us that $ds = \sqrt{dx^2 + dy^2}$. Using this expression for ds we can see that

$$
\begin{aligned}
ds &= \sqrt{dx^2 + dy^2} && \text{\# Figure 3} \\
&= \sqrt{dg^2 + dh^2} && \text{\# switch to parametric form: } x = g(t) \text{ and } y = h(t) \\
&= \sqrt{dg^2 + dh^2} \cdot \frac{dt}{dt} && \text{\# multiply by } 1 = \frac{dt}{dt},\ dt > 0 \\
&= \sqrt{dg^2 + dh^2} \cdot \left[\sqrt{\frac{1}{dt^2}} \cdot dt\right] && \text{\#} \ \frac{x}{x} = \sqrt{\left(\frac{1}{x}\right)^2} \cdot x = \sqrt{\frac{1}{x^2}} \cdot x,\ x > 0 \\
&= \sqrt{\left(dg^2 + dh^2\right) \cdot \left(\frac{1}{dt^2}\right)} \cdot dt && \text{\# simplify} \\
&= \sqrt{\left(\frac{dg}{dt}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{dh}{dt}\right)^2} \cdot dt && \text{\# simplify} \\
&= \sqrt{g'(t)^2 + h'(t)^2} \cdot dt && \text{\# switch notation from Leibniz} \rightarrow \text{Lagrange: } \frac{df}{dt} = f'(t) \\
&= \left\|\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt}\right\| \cdot dt && \text{\# Equation (4) and the definition of } \|\cdot\|
\end{aligned}
$$

In any event, now we see that

$$
\frac{ds}{dt} = \left\|\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt}\right\| \tag{5}
$$

and so

$$
\frac{ds}{dt} = \|\dot{\mathbf{r}}\| \tag{6}
$$

Since $\frac{ds}{dt} = \left\|\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt}\right\| = \|\dot{\mathbf{r}}\|$ we also know that the unit tangent vector $\mathbf{T} = \frac{\dot{\mathbf{r}}}{\|\dot{\mathbf{r}}\|} = \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{ds}$ [4]. One way to see this is to notice that

$$
\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{T} &= \frac{\dot{\mathbf{r}}}{\|\dot{\mathbf{r}}\|} && \text{\# definition of the unit tangent vector } \mathbf{T} \\
&= \frac{\left(\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt}\right)}{\|\dot{\mathbf{r}}\|} && \text{\# definition of } \dot{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} \\
&= \frac{\left(\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt}\right)}{\left(\frac{ds}{dt}\right)} && \text{\# Equation (6): } \|\dot{\mathbf{r}}\| = \frac{ds}{dt} \\
&= \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{ds} && \text{\# simplify}
\end{aligned}
$$

5 Conclusions

Acknowledgements

LaTeX Source

References

[1] Alex Svirin. Properties of Limits. https://math24.net/properties-limits.html. [Online; accessed 14-November-2021].

[2] David Meyer. Notes on Change of Basis. https://davidmeyer.github.io/qc/change_of_basis.pdf, January 2019. [Online; accessed 14-March-2022].

[3] Galbis, A. and Maestre, M. *Vector Analysis Versus Vector Calculus*. Universitext. Springer New York, 2012.

[4] Gregory Hartman. Unit Tangent and Normal Vectors. https://sites.und.edu/timothy.prescott/apex/web/apex.Ch12.S4.html, Nov 2021. [Online; accessed 08-March-2022].

[5] Jean H. Gallier. Vector Norms and Matrix Norms. https://www.cis.upenn.edu/~cis515/cis515-11-sl4.pdf, 2020. [Online; accessed 10-March-2022].

[6] NIST. Joplin Missouri Tornado 2011. https://www.nist.gov/disaster-failure-studies/joplin-tornado-ncst-investigation, Aug 2011. [Online; accessed 10-March-2022].

[7] Wikipedia contributors. Linearity of Differentiation — Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia. https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Linearity_of_differentiation&oldid=1026177205, 2021. [Online; accessed 1-September-2021].

[8] Wikipedia Contributors. Triangle Inequality — Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia. https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Triangle_inequality&oldid=1074965160, 2022. [Online; accessed 10-March-2022].